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En 180

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Reliable Unreliability – Narrative Bias in Autofiction

Narrative unreliability in fiction presents a compelling paradox: the more subjectively biased a narrator appears, the more reliably they reveal their authentic self. Across literary history, such narrative unreliability has captivated readers precisely because it mirrors our inherently subjective experiences. Consider Humbert Humbert in Vladimir Nabokov's *Lolita*, whose charismatic yet morally distorted voice seduces readers into overlooking his crimes. Similarly, John Dowell in Ford Madox Ford's *The Good Soldier* frames his account through emotional prejudice, prompting readers to question the reliability and accuracy of his perceptions. Even in novels featuring non-human narrators, such as Kazuo Ishiguro's artificially created protagonists, Klara and Kathy, humanlike emotional biases become central, further highlighting the fundamental role subjectivity plays in narrative engagement. Unreliability, or the presence of emotional bias, is the very thing that ties us to these characters, creating profound connections between reader and narrator.

Autofiction intensifies reader engagement by foregrounding the question of reliability in ways conventional fiction cannot. By intertwining fictional elements with autobiographical material, autofiction compels readers to interrogate the authenticity underlying narrative voice, creating what Meg Jensen, drawing on Sianne Ngai, in Jensen's essay *How Art Constitutes the Human*, identifies as a central paradox where the narrative “‘inevitably diverts attention away

from itself so as to throw the spotlight entirely on the question of its own legitimization’” (Jensen, 12). This diversion creates a situation where, by openly questioning its authenticity, the autofictional narrative “simultaneously highlights and obscures the veracity or otherwise of its factual details and ‘real life’ identities” (Jensen, 12). Unlike purely fictional narrators, autofictional narrators operate with fundamental self awareness about this boundary-crossing, making their reliability both more suspect and intriguing. Jensen argues that autofictional characters engage readers’ “curiosity and empathy, precisely because they proclaim their fictional status while simultaneously hinting (via paratexts, such as author biographies, prefaces, photographs and the like) that there may be truths hidden within” (Jensen, 15). This tension between fiction and reality creates a unique narrative contract with readers, who approach the text searching for authentic insights within the acknowledged artifice.

The question of reliability in autofiction thus takes on greater complexity than in conventional fiction. As Judith Butler suggests in her book, *Senses of the Subject*, there exists an inevitable gap between experience and narration: “If I say that I am already affected before I can say ‘I,’ I am speaking much later than the process I seek to describe” (Butler, 2). This temporal and psychological distance means that complete objectivity in narration is impossible, as emotional processes inevitably alter perception between story and discourse. By this standard, every memoir and autofictional work contains inherent unreliability. However, this unreliability paradoxically becomes the source of the work’s deepest truth and appeal. Butler notes that “one’s unbelievable narration is compelling for its own reasons,” precisely because it introduces readers to the narrator’s “remarkable self-understanding” (Butler, 4). Within this theoretical framework, Rachel Cusk’s autofictional novel *Outline* shows how narrative unreliability in autofiction can reveal more profound truths than ostensibly objective accounts ever could.

In *Outline*, the paradox of narrative unreliability achieves a particular ethical resonance through Faye's distinctive strategy of rarely speaking directly about herself, instead selectively reporting others' stories while inadvertently creating a reliable portrait of her own psychological landscape. This narrative approach, characterized by apparent emotional distance yet precise curation, establishes a deeper form of reliability precisely through its superficial unreliability, a phenomenon Butler highlights: "What [the narrator] relates may or may not be true, but it hardly matters, once we understand that the story he reaches for says something about his authorial ambitions and desires" (Butler, 4). By examining this paradox through Cusk's autofictional approach, we see how Faye's seemingly objective stance reveals her most authentic fixations, functioning not as a literary shortcoming but as the ethical core of the novel. *Outline* thus demonstrates how unreliability in autofiction creates a unique tension between authenticity and artifice that both invites and challenges reader empathy, suggesting through Faye's unconscious biases that our deepest understanding of human experience surfaces when we break through the claims of objectivity.

Though she operates primarily as a receptacle for others' stories, Faye's choice to retell stories consistently reveal her own preoccupations, particularly regarding financial status—an area where she herself struggles. Despite her seemingly neutral stance, Faye repeatedly highlights details about wealth and class in her retellings. At the very start of the novel, her judgments begin to become apparent in her description of the billionaire, who "had bought himself in, and out, of a great many things" (Cusk, 3). This seemingly objective observation subtly conveys Faye's underlying attitudes toward wealth and privilege. What appears initially as detached reporting becomes, in this way, a mirror reflecting her own struggles, however opaquely. This pattern continues throughout the novel as Faye consistently preserves and

emphasizes financial details that might otherwise seem incidental. She includes her plane seat neighbor's comment that "like all wealthy people [...] his parents had long outgrown their origins and moved in a borderless sphere among other people of wealth and importance" (Cusk, 8). While attributing this observation to her neighbor in noting that it was "he [who] continued", Faye's decision to preserve this particular characterization in her retelling reveals her attentiveness to class dynamics. Similarly, when paraphrasing Penelope's story about a broken glass panel, Faye notes that the owner "was annoyed [by the crack in the glass], because the panel had cost a considerable amount of money" (Cusk, 155). These seemingly incidental mentions of wealth accumulate throughout the novel, creating a pattern that reliably reflects Faye's own financial anxieties, which are later confirmed when we learn that her loan application has been rejected.

Butler's theoretical framework helps explain this phenomenon of selective attention. She suggests that "we cannot quite find a way out of the constraints of adult life except by asking how those incipient passages remain with us, recurring still and again" (Butler, 4). This persistence of past concerns in present narratives illuminates why Faye repeatedly emphasizes others' financial circumstances—her narrative choices reliably reflect her own unresolved economic anxieties. Rather than directly addressing her financial struggles, Faye processes them indirectly through her careful attention to others' relationships with money. This pattern reinforces Butler's insight that storytelling inevitably echoes and reenacts unresolved emotional tensions, creating a narrative that is simultaneously unreliable in its objectivity yet deeply reliable in its reflection of subjective truth.

Faye's treatment of personal relationships follows a similar pattern of indirect revelation, forming the second major preoccupation evident in her narrative choices. When her seat

neighbor asks why her marriage ended, Faye responds abstractly, reflecting on “what was real” and describing the loss of her house as “the geographical location for things that had gone absent and which represented, [she] supposed, the hope that they might one day return” (Cusk, 12). This evasive, metaphorical response initially appears to be withholding information, creating a narrative gap. However, through Elaine Blair’s interpretive lens, one can recognize that Faye’s evasiveness is not mere avoidance but rather reflects her ongoing attempt to understand her own experience through close examination of others’. As Blair notes in her essay *All Told*, Faye “[attends] very closely to what other people say about their own marriages, as though searching for a key to hers” (Blair, 5).

Yet, Faye’s own critical awareness of narrative unreliability surfaces when she comments on her airplane seatmate’s story. She observes that “the narrative invariably showed certain people—the narrator and his children—in a good light, while the wife was brought in only when it was required of her to damn herself further” (Cusk, 30). Faye recognizes that “the truth was being sacrificed to the narrator’s desire to win” (Cusk, 30). This meta-commentary positions Faye as an astute reader of others’ narratives while ironically highlighting her own parallel strategies. Her heightened sensitivity to narrative manipulation in others’ stories about personal relationships becomes another reliable indicator of her own absorption with her failed marriage. Faye’s selective skepticism further reveals her biases about relationships. She notes that she “didn’t entirely believe in [the second wife]. She was rolled out as an all-purpose villain, but what wrong, really, had she done?” (Cusk, 25). This moment of doubt might initially suggest Faye’s commitment to objectivity, but it actually manifests from her own biases about marriages and relationships. Similarly, her description of Ryan noticing a “young and beautiful” waitress with “long ringlets of hair on either side which she kept tucking behind her ears” (Cusk, 36)

projects Faye's judgments onto both characters. These projections are later partially validated when Ryan calls the waitress "beautiful" and asks her to "run away with [him]" (Cusk, 42), despite claiming to have a "good partnership" with his wife. As Blair observes, though these details suggest Ryan "is not a sympathetic figure" (Blair, 5), this moment of slight infidelity and the majority of his chapter exploring his complex relationship with writing and marriage echo themes that clearly resonate with Faye's own situation.

Blair suggests that "as Cusk's characters talk about their romantic and domestic situations, echoes and symmetries emerge between their testimonies" (Blair, 6). Each story earns its place in the novel because it reliably reflects Faye's underlying preoccupations. Her detailed attention to other people's relationships becomes a form of displaced self-inquiry, indirectly exposing her unresolved emotional landscape. This pattern throughout the novel illustrates Jensen's argument that "ambiguity is itself the essence of the autofictive narrative" (Jensen, 13). In Faye's case, this ambiguity manifests when her narrative choices most reliably reveal her subjective concerns precisely at moments when she appears most detached or removed from her subject matter.

The recurring patterns in Faye's narrative choices create a certain reliability through preoccupation. Though her indirect style initially suggests definitive unreliability, the consistent emergence of certain themes, namely wealth and marriage, paradoxically becomes a form of reliability, consistently revealing truths about Faye's internal emotional landscape. What appears to be an unreliable, fragmented approach to narration ultimately forms a coherent portrait of her most authentic concerns. This reinforces autofiction's unique capacity to engage readers' empathy through its simultaneity of fictional distance and emotional authenticity, as Jensen cites Catherine Cusset's argument that "the autofiction writer is anything but egocentric. [The

narrative] is not centred on the self, but erasing the self so as to make the truth of past emotion emerge” (Jensen, 7). Faye’s carefully constructed narrative distance becomes a strategy for indirect but profound self-revelation.

By strategically distancing herself and avoiding direct self-disclosure, Faye creates protective emotional layers while simultaneously inviting readers to participate in constructing her narrative through interpretation of patterns and silences. As Butler suggests, “[the narrator], personally, cannot go back to that place, nor can [the narrator] do so in an impersonal way. And yet there seems to be much we can still say” (Butler, 4). Faye’s narrative approach acknowledges this impossibility to return to her own places of hurt by embedding her emotional bias within others’ stories rather than attempting direct representation. This approach creates ethical indirection, where emotional authenticity emerges not through explicit confession but through the reliable patterns of a narrator’s selective attention and judgment. Although Faye does not reveal much about her own failed marriage and her financial situation, we can gather bits and pieces through the stories she chooses to include in the novel. It almost seems as though Faye is acknowledging her own refusal and inability to openly address her personal life. Instead, she indirectly communicates her anxieties and vulnerabilities by carefully curating stories that mirror her hidden concerns, crafting emotional distance that paradoxically brings readers closer to her authentic experience.

This paradox has significant implications for how narrative ethics in autofiction can be understood. If complete objectivity in narration is impossible, as Butler suggests, then the most ethical approach may be precisely what Cusk demonstrates through Faye: a narrative voice that acknowledges its limitations and biases through form rather than explicit statement. Faye’s unreliability does not undermine her trustworthiness as a narrator but instead confirms it,

grounding the novel's ethics in her candid if indirect depiction of personal biases and vulnerabilities. *Outline* thus offers not just a compelling character study but a meaningful suggestion that the most reliable insights into human subjectivity emerge precisely where objectivity appears to falter.